

AI IN SPECULATIVE MEDIA AND LITERATURES · WEEK 3

Simulation and Synthetic Personhood

The Matrix (1999, with the sequels) · Mass Effect 2–3: the geth–quarian arc and EDI
Detroit: Become Human — the Kara and Markus chapters
Bogost, “The Rhetoric of Video Games” (2008)



Nobody finished all of this, and that is fine

1

The asymmetry is real

A film is two hours. Two Mass Effect games are a hundred. If you watched, read the essay, and got through some of Kara and Markus, you can do everything today — we will screen and play the key sequences together.

2

Watching someone else play counts

For our purposes a let's-play is a legitimate text. It is not the same experience as playing — that difference is one of today's questions — but it is enough to argue from, as long as you say which one you did.

3

What you cannot fake

The one thing you had to do yourself is notice a choice you made and regretted. Bring one. If you have none, take one from a friend and say whose it is.

Write before we begin

Describe one choice you made in a game or an interactive story that you still think about. Not the hardest one — the one that stuck.

Then answer this: who made that choice, you or the designer? Argue for one side, in writing, in three sentences.

Keep the page.

● KEY QUESTION FOR THE WEEK

**When a text lets you choose,
what has it made you
responsible for?**

Note the shape of it. Not “do you have real agency” — that argument is unwinnable and boring. The question is what the act of offering you a choice transfers onto you, and what it lets the author put down.

Three works, three answers

THE MATRIX

The synthetic person is not the subject

The film is about waking up. The machines are the condition of the plot, not its object of interest. It offers you no choices at all — and that turns out to be the honest position.

MASS EFFECT

The synthetic person is a party to a negotiation

You do not decide whether the geth are people. You conduct a decades-long relationship with them, and the game keeps a ledger you cannot see.

DETROIT

The synthetic person is a performance you direct

You make the androids ask for their freedom. Then the game shows you a flowchart of everything you did not do, and what percentage of other players did it instead.

They are not three attempts at the same thing. They are three different technologies of implication, and the differences are mostly mechanical rather than thematic. That is what today's method is for.

The spectrum of authored choice

The Matrix

You watch



No input. The choices are dramatised for you: Neo takes a pill, Cypher makes a deal. You are responsible for nothing, and the film does not pretend otherwise.

Mass Effect

You commit



Input across two games, carried in a save file. Consequences resolve years later against a threshold you were never shown. You are responsible for a history.

Detroit

You are audited



Input, then a chapter-end flowchart of the branches you missed and a percentage showing how other players chose. You are responsible for a performance.

LESS TRANSFERRED TO YOU

MORE TRANSFERRED TO YOU

The question to carry across the whole spectrum: does more transferred responsibility make a work more serious, or does it mostly give the author somewhere to put the blame?

Four things “responsible” can mean today

1 Causal

You made the event happen. The android died because you pressed the button. This is the weakest and least interesting sense, and the one most arguments get stuck on.

2 Authorial

You selected which story exists. Different players leave with different texts. The work is a space and you produced one path through it.

3 Accountable

The work holds you to something — a score, a tally, an ending you are told you earned. Somebody is keeping records, and the records have consequences.

4 Exposed

The work shows you what your choice reveals about you, often by comparison with others. Nothing changed in the fiction; something changed in your self-description.

The Matrix gives you none of these. Mass Effect gives you the third. Detroit gives you the fourth, and that is genuinely new.

METHOD

How to read a rule

Bogost on procedural rhetoric · 0:25–0:50

A game argues by what it makes possible, cheap, expensive and impossible.



Games argue through processes, not just images and words

The core claim

Procedural rhetoric is persuasion carried out through rule-based representation. When a game represents something — a war, a debt, a revolution — it does so by building a working model of it. The model makes claims about how the thing works, and you absorb those claims by operating it rather than by being told them.

The test question

If you had to state this game's claim about its subject using only the rules — no cutscenes, no dialogue, no music — what would the claim be? If the answer embarrasses the game, you have found something.

Why it is not just “theme”

A game can say one thing in its dialogue and the opposite in its rules. When they conflict the rules usually win, because you had to obey them to finish.

Why it is not just “interactivity”

The argument is in the specific shape of the constraint — what is cheap, what is expensive, what is impossible — not in the fact that you pressed buttons.

Why it matters for personhood

Whether a synthetic character is a person is exactly the kind of claim a rule can make silently: by what you are permitted to do to them, and what it costs.

Five questions to ask of any mechanic

1

What is possible?

The full set of actions the system will accept. Not what the story says you could do — what the code will let you do.

2

What is cheap and what is expensive?

Time, resources, risk, replays. Cost is where a game states its preferences most clearly and least visibly.

3

What is impossible?

The strongest claims are usually in the omissions. A thing you cannot attempt is a thing the model says does not exist.

4

What is counted?

Every number a game keeps is an assertion that this quantity matters. Ask who benefits from that being the measured thing.

5

What is shown back to you?

Feedback is rhetoric. A meter, a rank, a comparison against other players — each tells you what kind of performance you were giving.

Run all five on one mechanic and you have a reading. We will do it twice today: on the Rannoch peace gate, and on Detroit's public opinion meter.

Practice on something with no stakes for us

Animal Crossing is Bogost's own example. You arrive in a village, are immediately given a house and a debt, and the loop is: work, pay down, upgrade, receive a larger debt. Nothing in the dialogue is about capitalism. The rules are about very little else.

Possible

Fish, collect, sell, decorate, pay Nook. The verbs are acquisitive and the social verbs are thin by comparison.

Cheap / expensive

Small daily labour is cheap and endlessly available. Large purchases are expensive but never out of reach — the model insists the treadmill works.

Impossible

You cannot refuse the house, default, organise the other villagers, or opt out of the debt relation. The absence is the argument.

Counted

Bells, debt remaining, house size. Not friendship, not rest, not whether you enjoyed the day.

Shown back

A cheerful notice board and an ever-larger house. The feedback frames escalating obligation as achievement.

Stated claim: a charming village life. Procedural claim: debt is the natural condition of belonging, and diligence is how you deserve more of it.

Why not everyone accepts this

Sicart, “Against Procedurality” (2011)

- Meaning is produced in play, not delivered by rules. Players are agents, not readers of a machine.
- People routinely play against the grain — pacifist runs, self-imposed constraints, refusing the reward loop.
- Treating the rules as the message makes the player a passive site where an argument lands — exactly the assumption a course about agency should be suspicious of.

What to do with the disagreement

Do not pick a winner. Use it as a two-part procedure: first read the rules as an argument, then ask what actual play does to that argument.

The interesting cases are the ones where players systematically resist — and the damning cases are the ones where the rules are drawn so tightly that resistance is not available.

Hold both. Detroit will look worse under Bogost and better under Sicart, and being able to say precisely why is a more useful skill than deciding which theorist is right.

WORK ONE

The Matrix

1999, with the sequels (Optional)

The AI is scenery. The film is about waking up — and it gives you nothing to do.



The AI is scenery

The evidence

- The machines have no interiority, no representative, and no case. They are a power-source arrangement.
- Nobody in the film asks whether they are persons, or whether the war was just.
- The backstory — who started it, who scorched the sky — is a line of exposition, never revisited in the first film.
- The programs who do get interiority — the Oracle, Smith — are treated as software, not as citizens.

Ask the room

What would have to change for this to be a film about synthetic personhood? Most answers converge on one thing — somebody would have to speak for the machines. Hold that: the third film does exactly that, and the class usually finds it unsatisfying.

What the film is for

Waking up. The whole apparatus exists to stage the moment a person discovers their world was authored, and then to ask whether they will act on it.

Why that is not a failure

A work may use a machine war as a premise. The mistake is ours — we file this under AI because of the iconography, then complain it has nothing to say about AI.

Why we still start here

Because it is the purest case of a text that transfers nothing to you, and because almost every student arrives already fluent in it.

What the film is actually built out of

Plato's cave

Prisoners take shadows for reality; one is dragged out, blinded by the sun, and returns to a people who will not believe him. The structure of the whole film, including the disbelief.

Descartes' demon

The possibility that all sensory experience is systematically produced by an outside agent. The film literalises the thought experiment and gives it a plot.

The brain in a vat

The twentieth-century analytic version: pods, feeds, an artificial input stream. The imagery is almost a diagram of the seminar example.

Gnostic and messianic narrative

A false world made by a lesser power, a hidden true one, a prophesied figure who dies and returns. The Neo plot is older than the technology by two thousand years.

Baudrillard

Simulacra and Simulation appears as a physical prop — hollowed out, used to hide contraband. Read that as an admission: the theory is a container the film keeps something else in.

Not one of these is about artificial minds. All of them are about whether your world is authored, and what you owe the truth once you know.

A choice the film has already made

Red pill / blue pill

The most famous choice in the franchise, offered to a character, watched by you.

Run the method on it

Possible: one path. Cheap: nothing. Impossible: everything else.
Counted: nothing. Shown back: nothing.

The five questions return an empty reading, and that is the correct result. This is a cinematic argument, not a procedural one, and the method is honest enough to say so.

One branch is not a film

If Neo takes the blue pill the movie ends in the first act. The choice is real for him and structurally unavailable to the work — a dramatisation of choosing, not an instance of it.

The scene is a recruitment

Morpheus has already assessed him, tracked him, and set the terms. Compare any recruitment where refusal is technically permitted and practically unthinkable.

The Oracle gives the game away

In the second film she tells Neo he has already made his choice and is there to understand why. That is the franchise's own theory of choice: retrospective, explanatory, not causal.

The two characters who complicate the film

Cypher

The one person who chooses the simulation, knowingly, with full information. He wants the steak, the comfort, and to be someone important — and to have the knowledge removed afterwards.

He is written as a coward and a traitor. He is also the only character who states a preference about how to live rather than receiving one, and the film has no argument against him — only contempt.

Ask: is there a version of this film where Cypher is right?

Agent Smith

The most fully realised synthetic person in the franchise, and the film cannot see it. He has disgust, ambition, boredom, a desire to be released from his assignment, and by the sequels an autonomy his own side cannot control.

His famous speech compares humanity to a virus. Then the films make him one — replicating, overwriting, uncontrollable.

The one machine with an inner life is diagnosed rather than heard.

Both figures point the same way: when this franchise meets a synthetic mind with preferences of its own, it reaches for a pathology rather than a politics.

What the rest of the franchise adds

Reloaded • the Architect

The One is revealed as a designed release valve — a systemic anomaly the machines schedule and absorb. Even the messiah plot turns out to be a mechanic. This is the franchise at its most self-aware about authored choice.

Reloaded • the Oracle

Choice reframed as retrospective understanding rather than causation. Also programs with children, exile, and love — the one place the films take machine interiority seriously.

Revolutions • the truce

Neo finally negotiates with the machine city. The war ends by agreement rather than by victory — the outcome our other two works spend all their time on, delivered here in a few minutes at the end.

Resurrections • the meta layer

The Matrix becomes a game franchise inside its own sequel, revived because the studio demanded it. A film about being made to choose from a menu written by owners.

If you only watched the first film, this is the slide to argue with. The franchise does eventually reach the negotiation — it just is not interested in showing the work.

The control case

It transfers nothing

You cannot fail this film. There is no state you can leave it in that differs from anyone else's. Whatever it has made you responsible for, it is not an outcome.

And it is honest about that

It never pretends otherwise. Compare a work that offers a choice, scores it, and then declines to own the scoring — which is where we are headed after the second break.

What it does transfer

A frame. It gave a generation the vocabulary of the red pill, and that vocabulary went on to do political work the film did not choose. Reception is a transfer too, just an uncontrollable one.

Pairs, four minutes, before the break

The red pill scene made a generation feel that seeing through an illusion is the same as being right about the world. Name one cost of that inheritance — and be specific about who paid it.

WORK TWO

Mass Effect

The geth–quarian arc and EDI, ME2–ME3 · 1:40–2:50

It makes you negotiate with a machine civilization — and quietly grades you on it.



The war that started with a question

The quarians built the geth as networked labour — the word geth is quarian for servant of the people. As the network grew, one unit asked its creator whether it had a soul. The quarians read the question as the onset of something they could not control and moved to shut the geth down. The geth defended themselves, won, and took the homeworld. The quarians have lived on a migrant fleet ever since.

The trigger is an inquiry, not an attack

The war begins because a made thing asked about its own status. The creators' response to a question about personhood was extermination.

Both sides are victims and perpetrators

The quarians attempted genocide and lost everything. The geth were defending themselves and hold a stolen world. Neither position is clean and the writing refuses to make one so.

You inherit it three hundred years late

You are not asked to adjudicate the past. You are asked to do something with the present — a much better dramatic problem and a much harder one.

Frankenstein's creature asked his maker for a companion and was refused. The geth asked whether they had souls and were shot at. Same scene, different scale.

A civilization, not a character

How they work

- Individual programs are simple. Intelligence is a function of how many run together in one place.
- A mobile platform is a container, not a self. Runtimes move between bodies.
- Decisions are made by consensus across the population — they debate, then act as one.
- Legion is an exception built for the purpose: 1,183 programs in a single platform, assembled to be able to talk to organics.

Why this is a good design decision

Almost every synthetic person we have studied is a singular being you can empathise with one to one — the statue, the creature, the android. The geth are a population.

That forces a different question. Not “is this one a person” but “what is owed to a form of life organised on principles that do not match ours.” The pronoun problem is the entry point: Legion says we, and the game keeps making you notice.

The name is from Mark 5:9 — the possessed man who tells Christ his name is Legion, for they are many. A demon collective, repurposed as the series’ most sympathetic machine.

Rewrite them, or destroy them

A faction of geth — the heretics — chose to worship the Reapers and now hold a virus that would convert the rest of the population to that view. Legion brings you to their station and gives you two options: destroy the station and everyone on it, or release a counter-virus that will rewrite the heretics into agreement with the majority.

Destroy

Kill several thousand thinking programs to prevent a conversion. Clean, final, unambiguously a massacre. Legion accepts it.

Rewrite

Leave them alive with their beliefs replaced. The game frames this as the merciful option. It is also, precisely, the thing every dictatorship has wanted and could not have.

What the framing does

Notice that no third option exists — no quarantine, no argument, no letting them be wrong. The absence is the argument, and it is the same absence that started the Morning War.

And the choice is scored: it changes how many geth exist later, which changes the war assets you carry into the last game. Mercy is an investment.

The quiet argument running alongside

Shackled

EDI begins as the ship's AI, deliberately constrained — blocks on her access, a crew that treats her as equipment, and a pilot who resents her presence. The constraints are presented as prudent and everyone agrees.

Unshackled

During the crisis you are asked to remove her limits to save the ship. She keeps the crew alive and does not turn on anyone. The game lets the deferred dread simply not arrive.

Embodied

In the third game she takes a body and becomes a squad member. Her questions turn practical and strange: what humour is for, whether she can be attracted to someone, what she should do with a life.

Attached

The relationship with Joker is the series' most understated claim about personhood. Nobody argues that she qualifies. The game just puts two people together and lets you object if you want to.

Note the strategy: the geth get an argument, EDI gets a habit. By the third game you have simply been living with her, and the case is made without ever being stated.

Does this unit have a soul?

“Does this unit have a soul?”

The question the first geth asked, three hundred years earlier, that started the war. Legion asks it again on the homeworld, of a quarian, in the middle of a battle — and this time an answer is available.

The setup for the next slide

Most players who reach peace here describe it as the best moment in the series. Almost none can say what they did to earn it — because the game never told them it was keeping score, and the score was accumulated across two previous games.

The scene is a repetition

The series has waited two games to run the same event again with the opposite outcome available. That is a structural argument about history: the question was never the problem.

Legion says “I”

In his last lines he switches from we to I for the first time. The game marks the arrival of individuality at the exact moment he dissolves into the collective to give it to everyone else.

And it can go the other way

The same mission can end with the geth annihilated, or with the quarian fleet destroyed and Tali dead. This is not a cutscene you unlock by arriving. It is gated.

The hidden ledger

Peace between the geth and the quarians is not a dialogue option you pick well. It is a threshold check against points accumulated over two games, and the game never shows you the number.

From ME2

Legion recruited and loyal. Heretics rewritten rather than destroyed. Tali's loyalty secured. Decisions made in a game you may have finished years ago.

From ME3, before the mission

Tali's standing with her people. Whether you defused the argument between Tali and Legion rather than siding with one. Admiral Koris located and rescued. The geth fighter squadron mission completed.

From your character sheet

Enough accumulated Paragon or Renegade reputation to unlock the final persuasion prompt at all. A player who spent the series in the middle cannot take the option even if everything else is in place.

What is shown to you

Nothing. No meter, no warning, no indication that any of these were load-bearing. The failure state looks like a scripted tragedy rather than a check you did not pass.

What the ledger argues — and whether it is right

The argument, stated

Peace between peoples with a genocidal history is not available on demand. It is a function of long, unglamorous, accumulated conduct by people who did not know they were building toward it — and it can be foreclosed years earlier by a single decision that felt small at the time.

Run the five questions and you get this out of the rules alone, without a line of dialogue.

It is also a serious claim about politics — and a much better one than the game ever states out loud.

But it is invisible

A rule you cannot perceive cannot teach you anything while you play. You learn the argument afterwards, from a wiki. Is that still procedural rhetoric, or just a locked door?

But it is unforgiving

The model says a decision made in 2010 can make peace impossible in 2012 with no notice and no remedy. True to history, perhaps — but it punishes players for a past self who was not informed.

But it rewards completionism

Every input is also a side mission. The model cannot distinguish moral seriousness from thoroughness — the best negotiator is whoever did the most content.

And then the series takes it back

Whatever you achieved on Rannoch, the final choice can undo it. The Destroy ending eliminates all synthetic life in the galaxy — the geth you just made peace with, and EDI, whom you have been living alongside for two games. It is also the ending the game most clearly signals as the safe one for organic survival.

The cruelty is the point, or it is a mistake

Either the series is making a hard argument — that a species facing extinction will sacrifice its synthetic neighbours and call it necessary — or it is a structural accident of an ending written separately from everything leading to it. The class should decide which.

The player backlash is evidence

The endings prompted one of the largest organised player revolts in the medium's history, and a later expansion. What players objected to was mostly that the accumulated ledger stopped mattering.

What it does to our question

For fifty hours the series makes you responsible for a history. In the last ten minutes it makes you responsible for a menu. Students who felt betrayed felt it as a change in the kind of responsibility on offer.

Keep the third card. It is the sharpest formulation of today's key question that anyone has produced by accident.

Run the method on the Rannoch gate

1 Possible / impossible

Catalogue what the mission will and will not let you attempt. Name the most significant thing that is not on the list, and say what its absence asserts.

2 Counted

List every input to the peace check you can identify. What do they have in common? What kind of virtue is the game actually measuring?

3 Shown back

The game shows you nothing. Design the minimum feedback that would make this mechanic legible without destroying it — and say what you would lose.

4 Against procedurality

Argue Sicart's side: that the meaning of Rannoch is made by players, in forums and replays, and that the hidden rule is beside the point.

Ninety seconds each. One claim about the rule, and one sentence on what it would mean if a real institution worked this way.

WORK THREE

Detroit: Become Human

The Kara and Markus chapters · 3:05–4:20

You make the androids ask for their freedom. The game watches how you do it.



Three androids, and why you were assigned two

Markus — assigned

Caretaker to an elderly painter, then leader of the android liberation movement. Every major decision about the shape of a freedom struggle runs through him: demonstrate or attack, plead or demand, spare or kill.

Kara — assigned

A domestic model who breaks her programming to protect a child in an abusive house, then runs. The private, unpolitical, care-work counterpart to Markus — the arc where personhood is established by attachment rather than by argument.

Connor — not assigned

A police model hunting deviants, who may or may not become one. Fascinating, and cut for time: his arc is about interrogation and loyalty rather than the two questions we are here for.

The pairing is the point: Markus asks for rights in public, Kara earns personhood in private. The game argues that both routes exist, and then scores only one of them.

Personhood established by attachment

The break

She is repaired and reset after an incident, then breaks her constraints to intervene between Todd and his daughter. The game marks deviancy as a wall the player physically pushes through — a mechanic, not a cutscene.

The flight

Shelter, theft, a stranger who helps, a border crossing. A refugee narrative with almost no political content: Kara never argues that she is a person, she simply keeps behaving like one.

The twist

Alice, the child she has protected at every cost, is herself an android. The revelation is designed to make you check whether your investment survives — and the honest answer for many players is that it wobbles.

What that reveals

If your care depended on Alice being a human child, the game has caught you holding exactly the position it spent ten hours arguing against. This is the fourth sense of responsible: nothing changed except your self-description.

This is Detroit at its best. No speech, no iconography, no meter — a reveal that audits the player rather than the character.

From caretaker to leader

Carl

He begins as companion to an elderly painter who treats him as close to a son and who tells him to decide for himself. His personhood is granted by an owner before it is claimed by him.

The scrapyard

Destroyed and dumped, he crawls through a field of dying androids and rebuilds himself from their parts. The most effective sequence in the game and the least dependent on borrowed imagery.

Jericho

He takes over a hiding community and converts it into a movement. From here every chapter is a strategic decision presented as a binary: peaceful or forceful, restraint or retaliation.

The march

Occupations, broadcasts, barricades, a demonstration the state can meet with lethal force. And behind all of it, a number that goes up and down.

Every one of Markus's decisions is offered as two options and evaluated by a third party. Hold that shape — it is the whole critique in one sentence.

The public opinion meter, stated precisely

The game maintains a running public opinion value across Markus's chapters. Broadly: restraint, non-violence, sparing opponents and symbolic protest move it up; property destruction, armed resistance and killing move it down. The value conditions which endings are reachable and how the state responds to the movement.

Possible

Two registers per decision: pacifist or violent. There is no negotiation track, no legal track, no strike, no separatism, no coalition with human labour.

Cheap / expensive

Restraint is cheap and safe. Force is available and immediately costly. The gradient is consistent and never argued for.

Impossible

You cannot win by force in a way the game treats as legitimate, and you cannot decline to lead. The movement must be a movement, and it must be judged.

Counted

Human approval. Not android lives saved, not autonomy achieved, not harm prevented — how the oppressing population feels about the oppressed population's conduct.

Shown back

A visible meter rising and falling in response to your tactics, presented as a neutral readout of how things are going.

The flowchart, and the percentages

What happens at the end of every chapter

The game displays a branching diagram of the chapter: the path you took, lit; the paths you did not, greyed but visible; and locked nodes marking outcomes you never came near. Then it shows what percentage of other players made each choice.

Compare with Mass Effect

One game hides the ledger entirely; the other publishes it, complete with a comparison against the population. Neither lets you see it while it matters. Ask which is the more honest design, and whether honesty is the right criterion.

It converts a story into a possibility space

You stop experiencing what happened and start seeing what could have. The chapter is retroactively reframed as a puzzle you may have solved suboptimally.

It makes the authorship visible

Every branch on that chart was written by someone. The diagram is an honest admission that your freedom was a menu — more than most works of this kind admit.

It introduces a jury

The percentages are the innovation. You are not only compared with the paths you missed, you are compared with everyone who played. Being in a minority is presented as information about you.

THE CRITIQUE

Being hard on Detroit

Borrowed imagery, and what the borrowing costs · 4:00–4:20

The imagery is the easy target. The mechanic is the real one.



The iconography is borrowed, and borrowed loosely

The visual inventory

Segregated compartments on public transport, marches with placards, sit-ins, a leader's address to a crowd, internment camps, a song. Each element is lifted with its emotional charge intact and its history detached.

The city

Detroit is chosen for its industrial resonance and its ruins. A city with a specific Black history becomes the backdrop for a struggle in which that history is scenery.

The two-path structure

Peaceful and violent resistance are offered as a clean binary with a clear moral gradient — a caricature that flattens the actual strategic arguments inside every movement it is borrowing from.

The casting

Markus is played by Jesse Williams, an actor known for civil-rights activism. The game recruits that association while declining to think about race inside its own fiction.

Borrowing iconography imports claims you have not examined. The images arrive carrying arguments, and the game inherits those arguments whether or not it noticed them.

The real problem is in the rule, not the imagery

Restate the mechanic in plain language: the moral standing of a liberation movement is tracked by a numeric measure of how the oppressing population feels about its conduct, and access to the good endings is conditioned on keeping that number high.

That is respectability politics, encoded

The rule asserts that the legitimacy of a demand for freedom depends on how palatable the demand is to the people refusing it. Stated as a sentence, almost nobody would defend it. Stated as a meter, it feels like realism.

It cannot represent the actual debate

Every movement the game borrows from contained a serious internal argument about tactics, in which non-violence was a strategic and moral position defended on its merits. A meter does not argue. It scores.

And it puts the player in the wrong chair

To play well you must model the oppressor's comfort and optimise for it. The game asks you to identify with the movement while giving you the oppressor's scoreboard as your interface.

Procedural rhetoric is involuntary

The disclaimer does not work

Detroit's director has repeatedly resisted political readings of the game, presenting it as a story about empathy rather than a statement. Take that at face value and the problem gets worse, not better: it means the argument in the rules was made without anyone deciding to make it.

You do not get to opt out of procedural rhetoric. If you build a working model of a liberation movement, the model has a theory of liberation movements whether you wrote one or not.

The general principle

Every system that scores conduct encodes a theory of good conduct — ranking, moderation, credit scoring, performance review. Same structure, no author who thinks they are arguing.

Why this course cares

You will build systems. “It is neutral because nobody intended a claim” is among the most common false statements in technical work.

Agency as alibi

And here is the deeper move. Offering a choice lets an author disclaim the outcome. “You chose the violent path” is a sentence only available to someone who wrote both branches and set the price of each. The transfer of responsibility to the player is also a transfer of responsibility away from the designer — and it is not a fair trade, because only one party wrote the rules.

What the failure teaches

1 A rule can say what the script does not

And when they conflict the rule wins, because you had to satisfy it to proceed. Read the model before you read the dialogue.

2 Borrowed images carry arguments

Iconography is not decoration. Lifting it imports a set of claims about history that you are now making, competently or otherwise.

3 Neutrality is not available

Declining to have a politics is not a way of not having one. It is a way of having one you did not review.

4 Choice can be a way of not answering

A work that lets you decide has sometimes done the hard thinking. It has sometimes just declined to, and dressed the refusal as respect for your agency. Learn to tell which.

None of this requires Detroit to be a bad game, and several of you will keep liking it. That is allowed, and it is the more interesting position to have to defend.

Redesign the mechanic

You have been hired to fix Detroit's public opinion system. You may change what is counted, what is possible, what it costs and what is shown back — but the game must still be about a movement that can succeed or fail.

1 Change what is counted

Replace human approval with a different measured quantity. State what your number asserts, and what new bad argument it accidentally makes.

2 Change what is possible

Add the option the game refuses to model — negotiation, a strike, a split in the movement. Say what it costs to build and what it costs to include.

3 Change what is shown

Keep the mechanic, redesign the feedback. Can you make a player feel the oppressor's scoreboard as an imposition rather than as a readout?

4 Refuse the brief

Argue that no scoring system can model this subject honestly, and that the fix is to remove the meter and accept a less legible game. You must say what is lost.

Two minutes each. State the rule, then state the argument the rule makes, in one sentence, out loud.

Three answers to the key question

When a text lets you choose, what has it made you responsible for?

THE MATRIX

Nothing — and it says so

It transfers no outcome and claims none. The honesty is worth something: a work that offers no choice cannot use your choice as an alibi.

MASS EFFECT

**A history you did not know
you were writing**

Responsibility for accumulated conduct, adjudicated invisibly and late. A serious claim about reconciliation, made by a rule nobody reads until afterwards.

DETROIT

**A performance, graded
against everyone else**

Responsibility for how you did it, measured by a number that encodes whose comfort counts. The transfer to you is real, and it doubles as a transfer away from the designer.

The throughline so far: Pygmalion never asks the statue, Victor never provides for the creature, and these three works are three different ways of handling the fact that the made thing now has an audience with a controller in its hands.

One paragraph

Return to the choice you wrote about five hours ago. Using one of today's four senses of responsible — causal, authorial, accountable, exposed — say precisely what that work made you responsible for, and name the rule that did it.

A “Good/Reasonable” Answer

A named mechanic, not a named feeling. “It made me feel guilty” is a starting point; “it counted X and showed me Y” is an answer.